Development of Parallel Applications with the Task-Based Paradigm and the StarPU Runtime

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SSCAD 2026 — Minicurso 3 — https://github.com/schnorr/starpu-tutorial

Opening

Today, 14:00–16:10, no break

14:00	10 min	Opening, start the containers	
14:10	15 min	Concepts: tasks, DAG, STF	exposition
14:25	15 min	Hands-on 1: first programs	`hello_world`, `vector_scal`
14:40	15 min	The StarPU runtime	exposition
14:55	30 min	Hands-on 2: tiled GEMM	`gemm_starpu`, GPU demo
15:25	10 min	Observing executions	exposition
15:35	25 min	Hands-on 3: traces and StarVZ	`starvz`
16:00	10 min	Closing, questions	

Everything is in the companion repository and in the book chapter.

Start the StarPU container now

First load the two images (handout, "Opening": from the archives distributed in the room, or with `podman pull`). Then:

```
git clone https://github.com/schnorr/starpu-tutorial.git
cd starpu-tutorial
podman run -it --userns=keep-id \
    --mount type=bind,src="$(pwd)",target=/home/starpu/mount \
    registry.gitlab.inria.fr/starpu/starpu-docker/starpu:latest
# inside the container
starpu_machine_display -notopology
```

You should see one CPU worker per core. Keep this shell open.

Concepts: tasks, DAG, STF

A typical HPC node

- One or more multicore processors, one or more GPUs.
- Each GPU has its own device memory, linked to the host memory by PCIe: 16 GB/s (PCIe 3.0 x16) to 63 GB/s (PCIe 5.0 x16).
- The bus is much slower than either memory.

Goal: compute $C \leftarrow C + AB$ using every core and the GPU.

Programming it by hand

```
unsigned jgpu = NB * 0.8;  /* GPU share: tuned by hand for this node */
cudaMemcpy(dA, A, ...); cudaMemcpy(dB, B, ...); cudaMemcpy(dC, C, ...);
cublasSgemm(handle, ..., gpu_cols, ...);              /* asynchronous */
omp_set_num_threads(ncores - 1);    /* one core drives the GPU */
#pragma omp parallel for collapse(2) proc_bind(close)
for (unsigned j = jgpu; j < NB; j++)
    for (unsigned i = 0; i < NB; i++)
        for (unsigned k = 0; k < NB; k++)
            gemm_block(BS, N, BLK(A, i, k), BLK(B, k, j), BLK(C, i, j));
cudaMemcpy(C, dC, ...);
```

Every line hides a decision valid for one machine only:

1. balancing the work, 2. managing memory transfers,
2. pinning threads, 4. porting to another node.

The task-based paradigm

- The programmer describes what: tasks, the data they access, and how they access it.
- A runtime system decides where and when each task runs, and moves the data accordingly.
- Implemented by PaRSEC, OmpSs, XKaapi, OpenMP (tasks with dependencies, 4.0), and StarPU.

Tasks, data, access modes

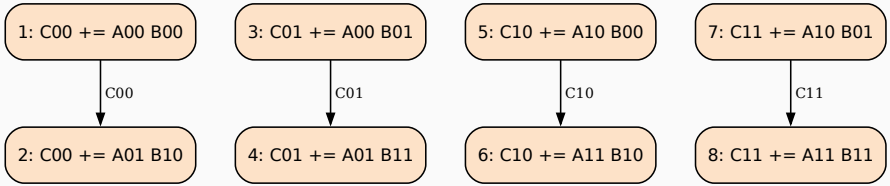
- Task: a sequential function applied to data blocks.
- Tiled GEMM: one task per (i, j, k) computes $C_{ij} \leftarrow C_{ij} + A_{ik} B_{kj}$.
- Each task declares an access mode per block: R for A_{ik} and B_{kj}, RW for C_{ij} (W only would be a bug).

Dependencies follow from the modes, in submission order:

RAW	T_1 writes, T_2 reads	true dependency
WAR	T_1 reads, T_2 overwrites	keep the old value
WAW	both write	keep the order

The programmer never writes them: they are implicit.

The DAG of the tiled product, $NB = 2$



Four independent chains of two tasks: each C_{ij} is updated twice (RAW), A and B are only read.

Work, critical path, granularity

- Work T_1: NB^3 block products.
- Critical path T_∞: NB block products (one per k).
- $T_1/T_\infty = NB^2$ bounds the number of busy processors: with $NB = 2$, at most 4 tasks at a time.

Granularity is a trade-off:

- larger $NB \Rightarrow$ more parallelism, smaller tasks ($2\,BS^3$ flops each);
- the cost per task is roughly constant, and GPUs need large blocks.

One of the few performance decisions left to the programmer.

Sequential Task Flow (STF)

```
for (unsigned i = 0; i < NB; i++)            /* the loops do not change */
    for (unsigned j = 0; j < NB; j++)
        for (unsigned k = 0; k < NB; k++)
            starpu_task_insert(&gemm_cl,     /* was: gemm_block(...) */
                STARPU_R,  starpu_data_get_sub_data(A_h, 2, i, k),
                STARPU_R,  starpu_data_get_sub_data(B_h, 2, k, j),
                STARPU_RW, starpu_data_get_sub_data(C_h, 2, i, j), 0);
starpu_task_wait_for_all();
```

- Submission is asynchronous; the runtime builds the DAG on the fly.
- Ready tasks run on any free unit while the main thread submits.
- Sequential semantics, parallel execution.

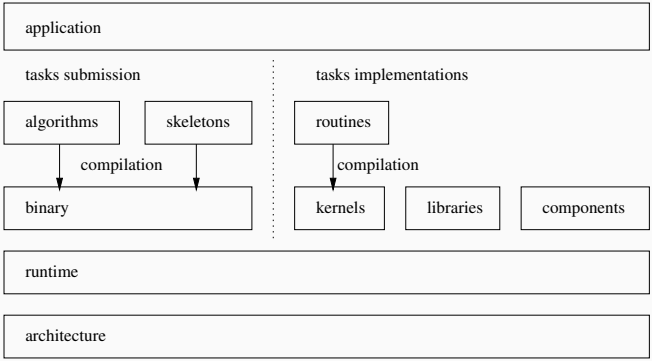
Hands-on 1 (15 min) — first programs

Handout, section "Hands-on 1":

1. Build the examples with `make`.
2. Run `hello_world` with 1, 2 and 4 workers.
3. Run `vector_scal`: two tasks, one RW dependency.

The StarPU runtime

StarPU in the software stack



C interface implementing STF; CPUs, CUDA, HIP, OpenCL, clusters with StarPU-MPI. Developed at Inria Bordeaux (STORM team).

Three components, three problems solved

- Scheduler (balancing): each ready task goes to a worker, chosen by a scheduling policy — from greedy to model-based.
- Memory nodes (transfers): main memory and each GPU memory; StarPU tracks valid copies and moves blocks before a task needs them.
- Workers (pinning): one thread per CPU core, one per GPU (on a dedicated core); one task at a time, no preemption.

Programmer-side abstractions: codelet (a kind of task), data handle (a registered block), task (a codelet applied to handles).

Codelets and tasks

```
void hello_cpu(void *buffers[], void *cl_arg)
{
    printf("Hello world from worker %d\n", starpu_worker_get_id());
    sleep(1);
}
struct starpu_codelet hello_cl = {
    .cpu_funcs = { hello_cpu }, .nbuffers = 0, .name = "hello",
};
int main(void)
{
    starpu_init(NULL);
    for (int i = 0; i < 4; i++)
        starpu_task_insert(&hello_cl, 0);
    starpu_task_wait_for_all();
    starpu_shutdown();
}
```

Data handles and access modes

```
struct starpu_codelet scal_cl = {
    .cpu_funcs = { scal_cpu }, .nbuffers = 1, .modes = { STARPU_RW },
};
starpu_data_handle_t vector_h;
starpu_vector_data_register(&vector_h, STARPU_MAIN_RAM,
                            (uintptr_t)vector, NX, sizeof(vector[0]));
starpu_task_insert(&scal_cl, STARPU_RW, vector_h,
                   STARPU_VALUE, &two, sizeof(two), 0);
starpu_task_insert(&scal_cl, STARPU_RW, vector_h,
                   STARPU_VALUE, &three, sizeof(three), 0);
starpu_data_unregister(vector_h);   /* data back in main memory */
```

- StarPU infers RAW: the second task waits for the first.
- Inside a task, `STARPU_VECTOR_GET_PTR` gives the address in the memory node where the task runs.

Partitioning and coherence

- Filters split a registered matrix into a grid of sub-handles: `starpu_matrix_filter_block` and `..._vertical_block`, applied with `starpu_data_map_filters()`.
- Dependencies are computed per block.
- Coherence protocol, as in processor caches: several valid replicas (one per memory node), invalidated on write, copied back lazily.
- `starpu_malloc()` gives pinned memory: asynchronous CPU–GPU transfers overlapped with computation.
- Implementations must read the layout (`STARPU_MATRIX_GET_LD`) from StarPU: a filtered block is not contiguous.

One codelet, several implementations

```
static struct starpu_perfmodel gemm_model = {
    .type = STARPU_HISTORY_BASED, .symbol = "gemm",
};
static struct starpu_codelet gemm_cl = {
    .cpu_funcs = { gemm_cpu },
#ifdef STARPU_USE_CUDA
    .cuda_funcs = { gemm_cuda },        /* calls cublasSgemm */
    .cuda_flags = { STARPU_CUDA_ASYNC },
#endif
    .nbuffers = 3,
    .modes = { STARPU_R, STARPU_R, STARPU_RW },
    .model = &gemm_model,
};
```

The scheduler picks the worker, hence the implementation, task by task.

Schedulers and performance models

`STARPU_SCHED` selects the policy at runtime:

- Greedy (`eager`, `lws` by default): first idle worker takes the task; may give a large task to a slow core while the GPU is idle.
- Model-based (`dm`, `dmda`, inspired by HEFT): estimate on which worker each task finishes first, with transfer times for `dmda`.

`STARPU_HISTORY_BASED` models record the duration of each implementation per data size in `~/.starpu/sampling/`:

- the first runs calibrate (`STARPU_CALIBRATE=1` forces it);
- `starpu_perfmodel_display -s gemm`, `starpu_perfmodel_plot -s gemm`.

The static 80% split becomes a task-by-task decision.

Hands-on 2 (30 min) — the tiled matrix multiplication

Handout, section "Hands-on 2":

1. Run `gemm_seq`, then complete the TODO of `gemm_starpu_todo.c`.
2. Run `gemm_starpu 2048 2` and `2048 8`; compare GFlop/s.
3. Try `eager` and `dmda`; look at the performance model.
4. Watch the GPU demo on the instructor's machine.

Observing task-based executions

Why traces?

- Time, speedup and efficiency are single numbers.
- They do not say why an execution is slow:
  - the DAG lacks parallelism?
  - workers wait for data transfers?
  - some tasks take longer than expected?
  - the runtime itself is a bottleneck?
- Answering requires looking at what happened: execution traces.

Recording a trace

- StarPU built with FxT (true in the tutorial image).
- At runtime: `STARPU_FXT_TRACE=1`, files in `STARPU_FXT_PREFIX`, written at `starpu_shutdown()`.
- `STARPU_GENERATE_TRACE=1` also converts them (`paje.trace`, `tasks.rec`, `dag.dot`) in the current directory.

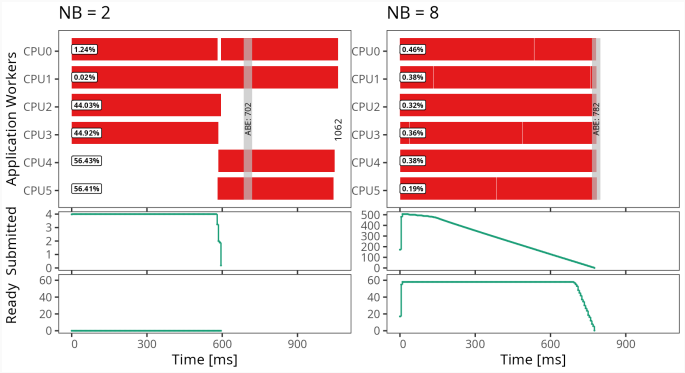
Two containers today: StarPU records and converts, StarVZ (`docker.io/viniciusvgp/starvz`) analyzes.

The StarVZ workflow

- Phase 1 (shell): Paje trace → compact `.parquet` files describing tasks, workers, handles and the DAG.
- Phase 2 (R): read them and build a figure of synchronized panels, selected by a YAML file.

```
starvz --use-paje-trace --keep --phase1 trace_nb8/
Rscript starvz_compare.R starvz_compare.yaml trace_nb2 trace_nb8 out.png
```

Reading a space-time diagram



Rows: workers; rectangles: tasks; left: idleness; gray band: ABE lower bound (ignores dependencies); bottom: submitted and ready tasks.

What to look for

- Gaps and few ready tasks: the DAG lacks parallelism ($NB = 2$).
- Gaps while many tasks are ready: runtime or data transfers (more panels on memory nodes and transfers).
- Tasks much longer than others of the same type: outliers, often interference.
- On a heterogeneous node: did the scheduler keep CPUs and GPUs busy?

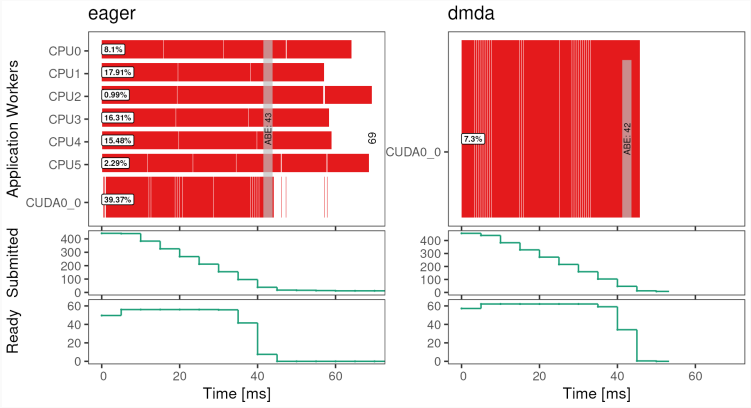
Hands-on 3 (25 min) — traces and StarVZ

Handout, section "Hands-on 3":

1. Record traces of `gemm_starpu 2048 2` and `2048 8`.
2. Phase 1 in the StarVZ container.
3. Plot both traces side by side; answer the questions.
4. Look at the instructor's CPU+GPU traces (`eager` vs. `dmda`).

Closing

CPU+GPU: `eager` vs. `dmda` (instructor's machine)



Same binary, 6 CPU workers + 1 GPU, $N = 2048$, $NB = 8$.

What we left out

- Distributed execution with StarPU-MPI (same STF model, across nodes).
- Reductions and commutative accesses (relaxing RW dependencies).
- Advanced schedulers (`dmdas`, `heteroprio`, ...), HIP and OpenCL.

Material:

- Book chapter and this repository:
  `https://github.com/schnorr/starpu-tutorial`
- StarPU documentation and tutorials:
  `https://starpu.gitlabpages.inria.fr/`
- StarVZ: `https://github.com/schnorr/starvz`

Questions?